

VOICINGS & TENSIONS

What is a voicing? What are tensions? The full reference for adding color above the 7th chord.

THREE THINGS WE CONTROL IN A VOICING

1

Which extra notes (tensions) we add

Upper extensions above the 7th: 9, #9, 11, #11, b13, 13 — add color and sophistication

2

What order we put the notes in

Positioning (P1, P2, P3) — the same notes rearranged change the register and feel of the chord

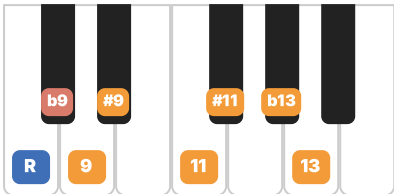
3

Which voicing we choose in adjacent chords

Voice leading — how the notes move from one chord to the next. Smooth = professional. Jumpy = amateur.

ALL 7 TENSIONS — SHOWN ON ONE KEYBOARD (ROOT = C)

Root Available Tension Avoid Note



TENSIONS REFERENCE TABLE

TENSION	LOWER INTERVAL	HALF STEPS FROM ROOT	NOTE ON C	FORMULA	TYPE
b9	b2	1	D $\flat$	b2 + 7 = b9	Avoid ✗
9	2	2	D	2 + 7 = 9	Available ✓
#9	#2	3	E $\flat$	#2 + 7 = #9	Available ✓
11	4	5	F	4 + 7 = 11	Available ✓
#11	#4	6	G $\flat$	#4 + 7 = #11	Available ✓
b13	b6	8	A $\flat$	b6 + 7 = b13	Available ✓
13	6	9	A	6 + 7 = 13	Available ✓

SPECIAL CASE — B5 / #11

The **b5** is technically a tension too — same pitch as #11 but used in a different context. When written as *#11*, it is an upper extension (tension above the chord). When written as *b5*, it replaces the 5th as a chord tone (e.g., the half-diminished chord). Same key on the piano, different harmonic meaning.